

Communications/Stakeholder Engagement Subcommittee Meeting
November 10, 2020
5:30 to 6:30 via Zoom
Meeting Minutes

Facilitator: Jenny Graham

Members, Kathy Kreatz and Melanie McLaughlin present

5:34 Jenny Graham read introduction.

Meeting Objectives: Discuss plan for Kindergarten information sessions, enrollment plans, and community outreach for to address the below approved motion:

The SC refers our k orientation practices to the C/CE/SP subcommittee for review. The subcommittee will also review current communication and community engagement practices related to k orientation. The subcommittee will recommend revisions to the current plan and approach to the sc by Sept 30, 2020.

Call to order: three present (Kathy Kreatz, Melanie McLaughlin and Jenny Graham)

Jenny Graham shared screen with a chart comparing local districts with Medford. (include chart from Jenny)

Kathy Kreatz suggested virtual tours.

Peter Cushing: We did virtual tours for middle school but not for the Kindergarten.

Jenny Graham: Let's hang onto that thought about offering virtual tours.

Mystic Valley's process is open and applications are due January 4. Their website had no content regarding K and did not offer tours.

Prospect Hill: lottery in March. There is specific content about Kindergarten on the website.

Melrose: registration opens in February. Open houses in January and February. Options for tours in February. There is content specific information on the website.

Wakefield: later.

Somerville; emails eligible families in November. Registration starts January 12. Information sessions in November. Virtual tours before January.

Things we may want to do in future:

1. Use of census data (like Somerville)
2. Use of outreach to Medford Family Network
3. Outreach to local preschools

Melanie McLaughlin: it would be great to get approval on quotes and pictures on a google drive that we could use for PR purposes

Jennifer (community member): Brooks School did a virtual welcome tour back in July
Lisa E: Columbus and McGlynn did also do virtual welcomes.

Suzanne Galusi: Each school did their own tours but on their own.

Jenny Graham: asking Jennifer, Brooks K parent what her experience was in getting her child registered?

Jennifer (parent, also a SPED educator in Cambridge) went to the Bridges to Kindergarten event in March, and filled out her forms that night. Some forms didn't make it to where they needed to go so she filled them out again but then didn't really hear anything until July. Was hoping for K meetups and playgroups but those couldn't happen officially because of COVID. Once the end of August, regular emails started coming. I found out most stuff on Facebook first.

Jenny Graham: last meeting we did talk about proactively reaching out to Kindergarten families and setting expectations about what is to come. Last year we went to online registration out of necessity but now that we have it set up, it gives us something to think about this year. I would like to think about working with City Hall to reach out to Kindergarten families. I would like to bring this forward to the school committee to recommend. Should we move Bridges earlier and also have a questions and answers session.

Suzanne Galusi: Agrees that a mailing in December that spells out the steps for this year. Appreciates the comments about the videos. Will recommend that the four schools get on the same page with the content of these videos. It makes sense to bump everything up a bit.

Jenny Graham: Is online registration good to go?

Suzanne Galusi: It is ongoing through the year. There is always a follow up call from PIC to finalize the last steps of the registration. Sometimes it may need to go through nursing or SPED. It is a streamlined process but support with in person registration is there.

Jenny Graham: is it achievable to get a video done including all four schools. I did the video with Ms. Demos to show the parents life in a day of a Kindergartener. Jack Dempsey helped us with this project. Pickup and dropoff situations would need to be filmed separately.

Jennifer parent: our schools in Cambridge have family liaisons in each school. Maybe there could be a PTO contact person to guide incoming families, send out videos.

Suzanne Galusi: It was in the works at the Brooks to have a point person in the PTO to help new families. We had started a FAQ document and perhaps can replicate it at the other schools.

Jenny Graham: It would be great to publish something on the website with this information. I liked what Melrose had on our website. It would be great on the district website as well as on

each school's website. I was assuming no tours could be planned this year but perhaps some of these other things could bridge the gap. Can we open the registration process in January?

Marice Edouard Vincent(6:03): an idea that came to mind based on our current schedule, perhaps we could do small tours/open houses on wednesdays when things are better. Unfortunately they would be looking at the shields at each desk but at least they could physically see the buildings. That way parents could have the option to visit in the spring.

Melanie McLaughlin: Going forward a virtual tour as well as a live visit would be great to accommodate all needs.

Jenny Graham: From prior to COVID, I heard people mention that they wanted a tour but couldn't get one. Maybe there could be a time on a monthly basis when they could occur. I heard one of the schools had a google form where people could schedule a tour. Maybe there could be more of a systemic approach.

Does the timeline feel good to move bridges to k to Feb, and moving the tours in January? The letter in December should spell these events out.

Do we need to put it to the SC to be able to collect the census information to do the mailing? I wrote a resolution but am not sure that it is necessary.

Marice Edouard Vincent: since the census took place this year, hopefully we could get the information from there. MFN is an incredible resource. Marie Cassidy's mailing list is an incredible resource to us. Now that we have online registration does exist, a lot of this is doable. The Bridges presentations will most likely be virtual this February. To work on a FAQ, video. Letter in December is doable. The kids will be in beautiful facilities in all four buildings and offer the same physical layout but in your particular neighborhood.

Lisa Evangelista: Community Development at City Hall always has the most updated census information. Alicia Hunt is acting director right now and might be able to provide assistance.

Jenny Graham: what about the Medford census we fill out every year?

Lisa Evangelista: This should be in the City Clerk's office.

Jenny Graham: I feel the outcome of this meeting should be to bring it to the Committee.

Marice Edouard Vincent: I agree it should be brought to the SC floor but don't even think it needs to be a resolution. I can request it from Adam H at the city clerk's office this week. I will also reach out to Marie Cassidy. On average it is a list of low 300 students. We can work together to get this out in December.

Melanie McLaughlin: Should we have a process memo regarding a timeline for the future so we can lay out the steps for the future?

Marice Edouard Vincent: If it should be created as a policy, then it would need to be voted on at SC.

Melanie McLaughlin: It would be great to create a process so it is consistent across schools and also that we don't have to reinvent the wheel each year.

Jenny Graham: Last item on agenda was on survey of impact. I would like us to get a survey of feedback about their experience with K registration. How do we ask the right questions of families who registered and who didn't and find out if the timeline met their needs and also find out why some families didn't enroll? We don't have any insight as to what those issues are other than anecdotal evidence? How much money do we have to spend to save the money that goes to charter schools? This could be a trial run this year.

Melanie McLaughlin: How many of our students are incoming K that go elsewhere? At what other levels? At middle school, high school, what is the attrition rate for all levels? The survey should include other areas as well in order for us to solve the issue of paying less to the charter schools.

Jenny Graham: We could have a conversation at a future meeting about getting the precise number of funding that goes to the Charter schools?

Lisa Evangelista: The other layer is the parochial schools. Many families went parochial because of covid

Marice Edouard Vincent: I do believe some people made a temporary move to the parochial schools but because they need to pay tuition, they may return to Medford once covid is over. I believe the child care aspect is what drives people towards the charter schools. Starting this process earlier with better marketing will win families back. It will be interesting to see how families respond to this earlier timeline.

Jenny Graham: there was a parent who had comments but couldn't come to the meeting. I will share her comments when I receive them.

Marice Edouard-Vincent: The Kindergarten team is wonderful. Developmentally appropriate programs. Learning through play. Whatever level they come with, they grow and learn in Medford K. They receive an excellent foundation. Let's let the great work for itself.

Jenny Graham: I believe this work will go a long way.
Motion to adjourn the meeting approved 6:35PM.